Elaborating on the need to accord emphasis on technology, Ratan added: ‘I felt that the Tatas were absent from the high-technology areas of the 1980s. This was rather strange, for at the turn of the century, Jamsetji Tata had invested in pioneering long-gestation projects in emerging technologies. … I suggested using Tata Industries to break ground in creating expertise in long-gestation, high-risk enterprises, to emerge over time as the most experienced in those fields.’

This approach led him to start seven new businesses in the high-tech sector under TIL. One of the earliest plans to get off the drawing board was its entry into computers with Tata Elxsi. In 1979, a group of engineers, which included Thampy Thomas, an Indian from Stanford University, B. Kumar from the University of Illinois and Joe Rizzi of Intersil, an American semiconductor company, had started the company to compete with IBM, the giant in computers.

Thampy, who lived in Australia where his father served as the Indian High Commissioner, had become friends with Ratan, who was deputed there in November 1969 to explore new business opportunities for the Tatas. Realizing that Ratan was a man of ‘vision’ and interested in entering the field of high-tech, Thampy wrote to him.

It was the kind of opportunity Ratan was looking for. He quickly arranged for a presentation to be made to the Tata Sons board. JRD and Moolgaokar were ‘intrigued’ at the prospects of collaborating with a start-up, but with Ratan’s persuasion, the group chipped in with $3.5 million. Ratan was nominated to the governing board of the company, now called Tata Elxsi, and he ‘wielded a great deal of influence in terms of the company’s product positioning and strategy’. Tata Elxsi has grown to a substantial company with a revenue of Rs 2,470 crore in 2022 and a net profit of Rs 549 crore during the year.

Ratan also shepherded the group into other areas. In 1982, a leisure products company, CBS Gramophone Records and Tapes (India) Limited, with CBS International holding 40 per cent and the Tatas 50 per cent of the share equity, was set up. A new company called Tata Finance Limited came into being the following year for leasing-cum-hire purchase. It was set up as the auto financing division of TIL.

In 2005, Tata Finance was amalgamated with Tata Motors. It is a profitable company and had a turnover of over Rs 3,573.30 crore as of 31 March 2022. Tata Capital, which consists of Tata Capital Financial Services